IELTS Momentum

Elite IELTS 7.0+ · Band 6.0–6.5 to 7.0+

Student's Book · Week 3: Employment and careers

An IELTSflow Signature Course. All texts and tasks in this book are original IELTSflow material.

This week

Reading: matching information to paragraphs. **Speaking:** Part 3 – abstract and hypothetical questions.

Listening: matching opinions in Section 3. **Writing:** Task 2 – a nuanced position (partly agree) with PEEL paragraphs.

Grammar: advanced passives and reporting structures. **Sunday:** MOCK 3.

Week 3 · Lesson 1 Reading + Speaking

Topic: Ambition and success · **Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced:** Unit 5 · **Exam focus:** Reading – matching information, sentence completion; Speaking – Part 3

1 Warm-up: dream job auction (8 min)

In fours, you have 100 points to 'buy' the job qualities you want most: **high salary · job security · fulfilling work · flexible hours · fast promotion · good colleagues · working abroad · recognition**. Agree as a team, then explain your top two to another team.

2 Vocabulary: striving to achieve

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
ambitious	having a strong wish to be successful	She is **ambitious** and wants to run her own company by 30.
aspire to / aspiration	to have a strong wish to achieve something / such a wish	Many students **aspire to** work abroad.
fulfil your potential	to achieve as much as you are able to	Good teachers help students **fulfil their potential**.
setback	a problem that delays progress	Failing the interview was only a temporary **setback**.
persevere / perseverance	to keep trying despite difficulties / this quality	Success in IELTS takes **perseverance**.
resilient	able to recover quickly from difficulties	**Resilient** employees cope well with change.
fulfilling	making you feel happy and satisfied	Nursing is hard but deeply **fulfilling**.
burnout	extreme tiredness caused by working too hard for too long	Long hours led to **burnout** among the doctors.
driven	extremely determined to succeed	He's so **driven** that he rarely takes a holiday.
overcome an obstacle	to deal successfully with a difficulty	She **overcame** many **obstacles** to become a surgeon.

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
meritocracy	a system in which people succeed because of their ability	In a true **meritocracy**, family connections would not matter.
self-motivated	able to work hard without others pushing you	Freelancers need to be highly **self-motivated**.
high-flyer	a person who is very successful in their career	The bank recruits **high-flyers** from top universities.
recognition	praise or reward for your work	Staff want **recognition**, not just money.
work–life balance	the right amount of time for work and for personal life	Young workers increasingly value **work–life balance**.

Group work

Word experts: Pair A teaches words 1–8, Pair B teaches words 9–15: definition, your own example, one **collocation** (*suffer a setback, a highly fulfilling career, show perseverance*).

Find someone who … walk around and find a classmate who has **overcome an obstacle**, who **aspires to** work abroad, who knows a **high-flyer** … Ask one follow-up question each time.

Practice. Complete the sentences with a word from the list in the correct form.

1 After working 70-hour weeks for a year, she suffered from …….
2 Losing his first job was a ……. , but he soon found a better one.
3 Teaching isn't well paid, but I find it incredibly …….
4 Children from poor families are less likely to ……. their potential.
5 Employees who receive ……. for their work tend to be more loyal.
6 Freelancers have no boss, so they need to be very …….
7 Nobody gets promoted because of family connections here – it's a true …….
8 Thanks to her ……. , she finally passed the exam on her fourth attempt.

3 Reading: Passage 3 level

Exam strategy: matching information

1 The questions are **not in text order**, and some paragraphs may be used **more than once** (or not at all).

2 Each statement describes a **type of information**: *an example of …, a reason for …, a prediction about …, a comparison of …*. Underline that word – it tells you what to look for.

3 Read the passage **once quickly** and write a 3–4 word summary in the margin next to each paragraph. Then match.

4 Do this task **last** if the passage has other question types – you will know the text better by then.

Group work

Prediction (3 min): in threes, decide: will the writer say machines will take our jobs – yes, no or 'it's complicated'? Write one reason.

Solo exam work (20 min): answer Questions 1–13 alone, in silence.

Margin notes: compare your paragraph summaries (3–4 words) with your group. Choose the best summary for each paragraph.

Evidence check: agree answers – for each one, read out the exact phrase that matches the **type of information** (*a prediction* ➜ 'he predicted').

You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 1–13, which are based on the reading passage below.

Will the machines take our jobs?

Fears that technology will destroy work are as old as industry itself. History suggests a more complicated story.

A Few questions about the future of work cause as much anxiety as the rise of intelligent machines. Every new advance, from self-driving lorries to software that can write reports, seems to bring another warning that millions of jobs are about to disappear. Yet the fear itself is far from new. For more than two centuries, people have predicted that machines would leave large numbers of workers with nothing to do, and for more than two centuries the total number of jobs has, broadly speaking, continued to grow. Understanding why this has happened, and whether it will continue, is one of the central questions in modern economics.

B The most famous early protest against machinery took place in England between 1811 and 1816. Skilled textile workers in Nottinghamshire, Yorkshire and Lancashire, who called themselves Luddites after a mythical leader known as 'Ned Ludd', broke into factories at night and smashed the new knitting frames and weaving machines that threatened their livelihoods. The

government responded harshly: machine-breaking was made a crime punishable by death, and thousands of soldiers were sent to the affected areas. Today, 'Luddite' is often used as an insult for someone who simply dislikes technology, but historians point out that the original Luddites were not opposed to machines as such. Their anger was directed at employers who used them to cut wages and replace skilled craftsmen with cheaper, less experienced workers.

C More than a century later, in 1930, the British economist John Maynard Keynes gave the problem a name. In an essay called 'Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren', he warned of 'technological unemployment' – unemployment caused by our discovering ways of saving labour faster than we could find new uses for it. Keynes, however, regarded this as a temporary difficulty. In the long run, he predicted, technology would make societies so rich that, within a hundred years, people might need to work only around fifteen hours a week. Average working hours did fall during the twentieth century, but nowhere near as far as he imagined; rather than choosing more leisure, people in wealthy countries largely chose to consume more.

D One reason that the gloomiest forecasts have repeatedly failed is that technology tends to change jobs rather than simply remove them. A frequently quoted example comes from the work of the economist James Bessen, who studied the spread of cash machines, or ATMs, in the United States. When ATMs were introduced from the 1970s onwards, it was widely assumed that bank cashiers would soon disappear. Instead, their numbers did not fall, and even rose slightly, over the following decades. Because each branch now needed fewer cashiers, banks could afford to open many more branches, and the cashiers' role shifted away from counting notes towards customer service and selling financial products. Machines took over certain tasks, but the job itself survived in a different form.

E A similar pattern can be seen across entire economies. In 1900, roughly 40% of workers in the United States were employed in agriculture; today, the figure is below 2%, even though the country produces far more food than it did then. The workers who were no longer needed on farms did not remain permanently unemployed. Over time, they and their children moved into factories, offices, shops, hospitals and schools – into types of work that would have been difficult to imagine in 1900. Economists warn against what they call the 'lump of labour' fallacy: the mistaken belief that there is a fixed amount of work to be done, so that any task performed by a machine is a job permanently lost.

F This does not mean that the transition is painless. The new jobs that technology creates are often in different places from the old ones and require different skills, and the people who lose their jobs are not always the ones who find the new ones. The economist David Autor has shown that in many rich countries, recent technology has tended to remove 'middle-skill' jobs based on routine tasks, such as clerical work and some kinds of factory work,

while demand has grown for both highly skilled professionals and for low-paid service workers. The result, he argues, has been a 'polarisation' of the labour market, which may help to explain why many workers feel insecure even when overall employment is high.

G Estimates of how many jobs are at risk today vary enormously. In a widely reported study first published in 2013, the Oxford researchers Carl Benedikt Frey and Michael Osborne concluded that 47% of jobs in the United States were at high risk of automation within the following two decades. A later analysis for the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), which looked at the individual tasks within each job rather than at whole occupations, produced a much lower figure: around 14% of jobs across its member countries were found to be highly automatable, although a further 32% were likely to change significantly. The difference shows how much depends on whether a job is treated as a single unit or as a collection of tasks, only some of which a machine can perform.

H Some researchers believe that the latest generation of artificial intelligence may break the historical pattern, because it can perform tasks involving language and judgement that were previously thought to be uniquely human. Others point out that machines still struggle with what Autor has called 'Polanyi's paradox' – the observation, made by the philosopher Michael Polanyi, that 'we know more than we can tell'. Many everyday human skills, from understanding a joke to calming an upset customer, rely on knowledge that people cannot fully explain and that is therefore difficult to program. What seems likely is that the jobs of the future will reward precisely those abilities that machines find hardest to copy: creativity, complex communication and the capacity to keep learning.

Questions 1–7

The reading passage has eight paragraphs, **A–H**. Which paragraph contains the following information? **NB** You may use any letter more than once.

1 a prediction about how much people would need to work in the future ____

2 an explanation of why a technology led to more jobs of the same type ____

3 the punishment introduced for damaging machinery ____

4 a reason why estimates of job losses can be very different ____

5 a description of how one type of employment declined while production increased ____

6 an example of a human ability that is difficult to put into a computer program ____

7 the claim that technology has increased jobs at both ends of the labour market ____

Questions 8–13

Complete the sentences. Choose **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

8 The original Luddites were mainly angry with employers who used machines to reduce …….

9 Keynes thought that technology would eventually make societies so ……. that people could work far less.

10 Instead of having more free time, people in rich countries generally decided to …….

11 The idea that there is a fixed amount of work in an economy is known as the '…….' fallacy.

12 According to Autor, routine jobs such as ……. have tended to disappear.

13 The OECD study examined the ……. within each job.

4 Speaking Part 3: abstract and hypothetical questions

What changes in Part 3

Part 3 asks about **people in general and society**, not about **you**. Band 7 answers are **longer** (4–6 sentences), **more abstract** and show you can **speculate** and **see more than one side**.

A–R–E–A+: Answer directly · give a **R**eason · an **E**xample (general, not only personal) · then add an **A**lternative view or a condition (*That said, …, It depends on …*).

Function	Band 7 language
Generalising	By and large, … · On the whole, … · It's generally the case that … · People tend to …
Hypothesising	If … were to …, I imagine … · Supposing robots did most jobs, … · It would probably lead to …
Seeing both sides	That said, … · Having said that, … · Then again, … · It depends to some extent on …
Speculating about the future	I'd expect … to … · There's a good chance that … · It's hard to predict, but …

Group work

A–R–E–A+ relay: in fours, each person adds one part of the answer to the same question. Then one person gives the full answer alone.

Devil's advocate: in pairs, A answers; B must challenge (*But surely …?*); A responds with *That said, … / Having said that, ….* Swap after each question.

Expert panel: three students sit at the front as a 'panel'; the class asks Part 3 questions. Panel members must build on or disagree with each other politely.

1. Why do some people prefer job security to a high salary?
2. Is it better to stay in one job for many years or to change jobs often?
3. Do you think people will work fewer hours in the future? Why / why not?
4. What would happen if robots could do most manual jobs?
5. Should schools teach students how to choose a career?
6. Is it fair that some jobs are paid much more than others?

Week 3 · Lesson 2 Listening + Writing

Topic: Changing work · **Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced:** Unit 2 · **Exam focus:** Listening Section 3 – matching opinions; Writing Task 2 – a nuanced position

1 Vocabulary: time for a change (12 min)

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
automation / automate	the use of machines to do work previously done by people	**Automation** has transformed car factories.
obsolete	no longer used because something newer exists	Typists have become almost **obsolete**.
be made redundant	to lose your job because it is no longer needed	Two hundred workers were **made redundant**.
retrain / reskill	to learn new skills for a different job	Miners were **retrained** as technicians.
adapt (to)	to change in order to deal with a new situation	Companies must **adapt to** new technology.
transition	the process of changing from one state to another	The **transition** to online work was rapid.
upheaval	a big change that causes disorder	The industrial revolution caused social **upheaval**.
displace	to take the place of someone or something	Robots may **displace** warehouse workers.
phase out	to stop using something gradually	Paper forms are being **phased out**.
unprecedented	never having happened before	The pace of change is **unprecedented**.
revolutionise	to change something completely	The internet **revolutionised** retail.
inevitable	certain to happen and impossible to avoid	Some job losses are **inevitable**.
routine (adj)	done regularly in the same way; not creative	Machines are best at **routine** tasks.
complement	to add to something in a way that improves it	Technology should **complement** human skills, not replace them.

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
labour market	the supply of workers and the demand for them	The **labour market** for programmers is very competitive.

Group work

Future jobs debate: in fours, choose three jobs (*taxi driver, translator, nurse, accountant …*). Decide whether each will become **obsolete**, **change**, or stay the same by 2040. Use at least six words from the list, then compare with another group.

Practice. Choose the correct word.

1 Many bank clerks were (made redundant / phased out) when branches closed.

2 Older workers may find it harder to (complement / adapt) to new software.

3 The pandemic caused (unprecedented / routine) changes to the way we work.

4 Fax machines are now almost (obsolete / inevitable).

5 Good software should (displace / complement) the skills of doctors, not replace them.

6 The government is paying for factory workers to (retrain / revolutionise) as technicians.

2 Listening (18 min)

Listening slot: Cambridge IELTS 16, Test 4, Part 3 (choose two + matching opinions)

Matching opinions: you match each item to what a speaker **thinks** about it. The words you hear will be **paraphrases** of the options.

Before: rewrite each option (A–G) in your own words. Predict the **kind of opinion** (positive, negative, surprised, uncertain).

Watch for: *I'd assumed …, but actually …* (the first idea is wrong) · *Mind you, …* (a second thought) · *Exactly* (agreement with the other speaker).

Group work

Paraphrase pairs (4 min): each pair rewrites the options and swaps with another pair to check.

After (6 min): in threes, compare answers. For each difference, find the moment in the transcript and decide: which word was the **trap**?

3 Writing Task 2: a nuanced position

Essay question: Some people think that when employers choose new staff, personal qualities such as honesty and the ability to work in a team are more important than academic qualifications. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 7 position: clear AND nuanced

You don't have to choose 100% agree or disagree. A **partly agree** essay is often more convincing – but your position must be **clear from the introduction to the conclusion**.

Introduction: *While qualifications remain important for many professions, I largely agree that personal qualities matter more in most workplaces.*

Body 1: the side you **partly accept** (concession). **Body 2:** your **main** view – the longer, stronger paragraph. **Conclusion:** repeat the same position in new words.

Position	Introduction sentence
Completely agree	I firmly believe that … should take priority over …
Largely agree	Although … , I largely agree that …
Partly agree	I agree that … in some fields, but not in others, such as …
Largely disagree	While … , I would argue that … remain(s) more important.

PEEL paragraph – reminder

Present one clear idea · **E**xplain it (why / how) · give a specific **E**xample · **L**ink / Result – show what it means for the question.

Group work

Position line: stand on a line from 'completely agree' to 'completely disagree'. Talk to the people next to you – what is **your** strongest reason?

Idea storm (5 min): teams list ideas from different perspectives: employers · customers · colleagues · the type of job (surgeon vs salesperson) · the long term.

PEEL build: each team builds one PEEL paragraph on a poster – one person writes P, the next E, the next E, the last L. Gallery walk: tick the strongest example.

Task. Write your introduction and the main body paragraph (PEEL). Your partner checks: is the position the same in both?

Week 3 · Lesson 3 Grammar + Writing clinic + Speaking clinic

Grammar: Advanced passives and reporting · **Vocabulary Files C2:** Unit 3, Employment · **Accuracy:** Common Mistakes at Proficiency, Units 5–6

1 Warm-up: employment collocations (8 min)

Word / phrase	Definition	Example
job security	the likelihood that you will keep your job	Civil servants enjoy high **job security**.
career prospects	chances of progress in your career	The job pays little but has excellent **career prospects**.
a dead-end job	a job with no chance of promotion	He left his **dead-end job** to study.
climb the career ladder	to move to higher positions	She **climbed the career ladder** quickly.
be laid off	to lose your job because there is not enough work	Hundreds were **laid off** in the downturn.
work your way up	to start in a low position and gradually be promoted	He **worked his way up** from waiter to manager.
the gig economy	work made up of short, temporary jobs, often through apps	Taxi apps are part of **the gig economy**.
perks	extra benefits you get from a job, besides pay	Free lunches are one of the **perks**.
a heavy workload	a large amount of work	Teachers often complain of **a heavy workload**.
hands-on experience	practical experience of doing something	Internships give **hands-on experience**.

Group work

Career story: in threes, invent the career of one person from age 18 to 50, using at least six collocations (*She started in a dead-end job, but …*). Tell it to another group – they count the collocations.

2 Grammar: advanced passives and reporting

Group work

Discovery (5 min): compare: A *People say that the Luddites hated machines.* B The Luddites **are said to have hated** machines. Which is more academic? Why does B use **to have hated**? Write the rule as a group.

Structure	Example
It + passive reporting verb + that	**It is widely believed that** automation will create new jobs.
subject + passive + to-infinitive (now)	AI **is thought to be** the biggest change since electricity.
… + to be -ing (in progress)	Thousands of firms **are reported to be using** AI.
… + to have + past participle (past)	Keynes **is said to have predicted** a 15-hour week.
passive -ing / perfect participle	Nobody likes **being made** redundant. · **Having been trained** abroad, she …
passive modal (past)	The workers **should have been warned** earlier.
There + passive + to be	**There are thought to be** over a million gig workers.

Rules and warnings

1 Common reporting verbs: *say, think, believe, know, report, expect, estimate, consider, claim*.

2 Past event ➜ **to have + past participle**: × *He is said to leave the company last year* ➜ ✓ *He is said to have left …*

3 Don't mix the two patterns: × *It is thought robots to replace …* ➜ ✓ It is thought **that** robots **will** replace … / Robots **are thought to** …

4 Use these structures to sound **cautious and academic** in Task 2 – they show you are reporting a view, not stating a fact.

Exercise 1. Rewrite the sentences starting with the words given.

1 People believe that remote work increases productivity. Remote work …

_____

_____

2 Experts estimate that 30% of tasks could be automated. It …

_____

_____

3 People say the company paid its staff very badly. The company …

_____

4 Reports say that many young people are leaving the countryside. Many young people …

_____

5 They didn't warn the employees about the job cuts. (should) The employees …

_____

6 After she was promoted twice, she became a director. Having …

_____

Exercise 2. Find and correct the mistake.

1 The factory is said to close in 2015.

2 It is believed robots to replace many drivers.

3 Nobody likes being make redundant.

4 Having been train abroad, she found a job quickly.

5 There are estimated being 2 million freelancers in the country.

Group work

Rumour mill: each student writes a 'rumour' about a famous company or person (*Apple is said to be planning …*). Pass it on in a chain, each person reporting it with a **different** reporting verb. The last person reads it out – is it still grammatical?

3 Writing clinic: Lesson 2 paragraphs + Mock 2

Peer review – Band 7 Task Response checklist

☐ The position is **clear** in the introduction and the **same** in the conclusion.

☐ If you partly agree, the concession paragraph is **shorter** than the main paragraph.

☐ Each body paragraph follows **PEEL**, with a **specific** example.

☐ At least one reporting structure (*It is widely believed that …*).

☐ No sentence repeats the same idea in different words (padding).

Group work

Swap and question: swap paragraphs. Tick the checklist and write **one question** that would make the example more specific.

Mock 2 band hunt: in threes, compare your Mock 2 Task 2 marks. Which criterion is lowest for each person? Choose one sentence from your essay to improve together.

4 Speaking clinic: Parts 2 and 3

Describe a job you would like to do in the future.

You should say:

- what the job is
- what skills or qualifications it needs
- how you could get this job

and explain why you would like to do it.

Group work

Triads: candidate, examiner, observer. After the Part 2 talk, the examiner asks **two** Part 3 questions from Lesson 1. The observer listens for A–R–E–A+ and one hypothetical structure. Swap roles.

Observer checklist	✓ / ✗
Part 2: S–P–T–R or a clear structure; 2 full minutes	
Part 3: answers of 4–6 sentences	

An alternative view (That said, … / It depends …)	
A hypothetical or speculating structure	
At least three words from this week	

5 Accuracy slot: Common Mistakes at Proficiency, Units 5–6

Group work

Be the teacher: each pair corrects two sentences and explains the mistake to the class in one sentence.

1. She is working for this company since 2020.
2. I look forward to hear from you soon.
3. My manager made me to stay late every Friday.
4. Despite she had excellent qualifications, she wasn't hired.
5. The salary is depended on your experience.
6. It was the first time I have had a job interview.

Week 3 · Homework (3–4 hours a day)

Day	Tasks
Day 1 (after L1)	Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced Unit 5 · Record answers to all six Part 3 questions (A–R–E–A+) · Cambridge IELTS 17: one Reading passage with matching information (20 min)
Day 2	Cambridge IELTS 17 Listening Section 3 · paraphrase log (10 pairs from the transcript) · 10 sentences with this week's words
Day 3 (after L2)	Vocabulary for IELTS Advanced Unit 2 · **Writing: the full essay (40 min, 250+ words)**
Day 4	Grammar Exercise 3 · Record the Part 2 + 3 set below and send it · Reading: one Passage 3 + paraphrase log
Day 5 (after L3)	Rewrite your essay after the clinic · Vocabulary Files C2 Unit 3 · Common Mistakes at Proficiency Units 5–6
Day 6	Review all 40 words and collocations · Rest before **MOCK 3** on Sunday

Grammar Exercise 3. Write six sentences about work and technology using: is said to have · is thought to be · It is widely believed that · There are estimated to be · having been + past participle · should have been.

Speaking Part 2 + Part 3 (record and send)

Describe a person you know who has a successful career.

You should say:

- who this person is
- what their job is
- how they became successful

and explain what you have learned from them.

Then answer: (1) What does 'success' mean to different generations? (2) Is hard work more important than talent? (3) How might careers be different in 30 years' time?